APPSC GROUP 1 / GROUP 2 — HISTORY

Volume 1: Ancient India — explained from the basics

Sources · Prehistory · Indus Valley · Vedic Age · Mahajanapadas · Buddhism and Jainism · Mauryas · Post-Mauryas · Satavahanas and Ikshvakus · Sangam Age · Guptas · Harsha and early Andhra dynasties

READ THIS FIRST

How to use this book (read once):
1. Read chapter by chapter. Every topic follows one pattern: **What happened → How and why → Map or diagram → Remember → Andhra Pradesh link → Quick check.**
2. History is a story, not a list of dates. First understand the **blue box (In simple words)**; dates and names then stay in memory on their own.
3. Colours: **Blue** = simple explanation · **Orange** = Andhra Pradesh connection · **Red** = exam traps · **Green** = 2-minute revision · **Purple** = self-test.
4. Plan: one chapter a day (1.5–2 hours). Re-read only the green boxes after 3 days and after 10 days. Then attempt the History Mock Test given with this volume.
5. APPSC Prelims Paper I Part A (History and Culture) has 30 of 120 questions, mostly statement-based. So after each chapter ask: **can I say which statement is wrong and why?**

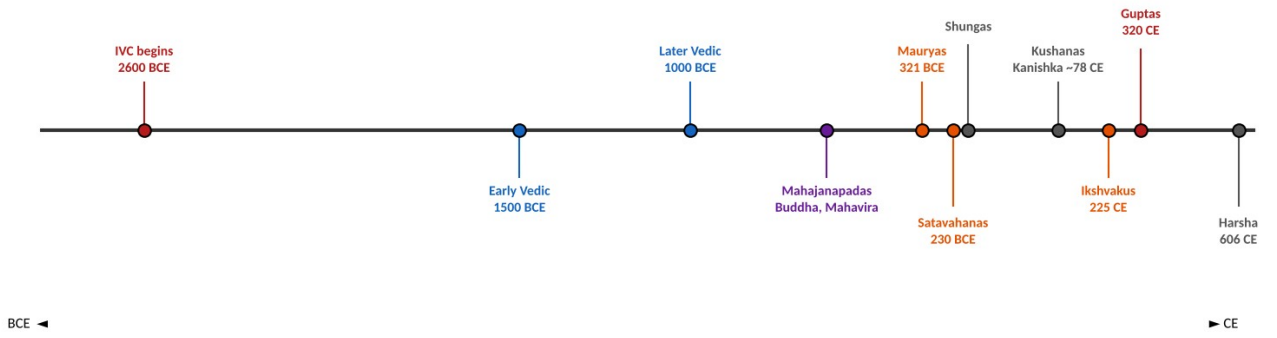


Fig 0.1 Master timeline of Ancient India (use it as your mental map for the whole volume)

Dating note: BCE = before the Common Era (old 'BC'); CE = Common Era (old 'AD'). Dates of early events are approximate; where sources differ the commonly accepted date is used.

CHAPTER 1 — HOW WE KNOW ABOUT THE PAST: SOURCES

Before the story, learn how historians read it

1.1 Why sources matter

IN SIMPLE WORDS (what / how / why)

History is built like a court case: no witness, no case. For ancient India there are three kinds of witnesses — **things dug out of the ground (archaeology), things written by Indians (literature), and things written by foreigners who visited**. A fact is strong when two kinds of witness agree.

1.2 Archaeological sources

Source	What it tells us / key facts
Inscriptions (epigraphy)	Most reliable: written at the time, cannot be altered later. **Ashokan Brahmi was deciphered by James Prinsep in 1837.** Earliest inscriptions in Sanskrit: **Junagadh (Rudradaman I, c.150 CE)**. Harappan script is still undeciphered.
Coins (numismatics)	Earliest: **punch-marked coins** (silver karshapana) c.6th century BCE. Indo-Greeks issued the first coins with portraits and names. **Kushanas** issued gold coins on a large scale; **Guptas** issued the most gold coins (dinaras). Satavahana coins are mostly lead.

Source	What it tells us / key facts
Monuments, pottery, tools	Stupas, caves, temples, cities show art and religion. Pottery types date layers: **Ochre Coloured Ware, Painted Grey Ware (PGW), Northern Black Polished Ware (NBPW)**.

1.3 Literary sources

Type	Examples and what to remember
Vedic and Brahmanical	Four Vedas, Brahmanas, Upanishads, Epics (Ramayana, Mahabharata), Puranas, Dharmashastras / Smritis (Manu, Yajnavalkya).
Buddhist and Jain	Tripitaka (Vinaya, Sutta, Abhidhamma), Jataka tales, Dipavamsa, Mahavamsa; Jain Agamas.
Secular / historical	**Arthashastra** (Kautilya – state, economy), **Mudrarakshasa** (Vishakhadatta – Chandragupta Maurya), **Harshacharita** (Banabhatta), **Rajatarangini** (Kalhana, 12th c. – first real history book), Ashtadhyayi (Panini), Mahabhashya (Patanjali).
Sangam literature (Tamil)	Tolkappiyam, Ettuthokai, Pattuppattu, Silappadikaram, Manimekalai – society and trade of the far south.

1.4 Foreign accounts

Writer	Who and what
Megasthenes	Greek ambassador of Seleucus Nicator at Chandragupta Maurya's court; book **Indica** (survives in quotations by later writers) – Pataliputra, administration, seven castes.
Periplus of the Erythraean Sea; Ptolemy; Pliny	1st–2nd c. CE. Describe Indian ports and Indo-Roman trade. Ptolemy mentions Andhra ports like Kantakossyla (Ghantasala).
Fa-Hien (Faxian)	Chinese monk; visited India in the time of **Chandragupta II (Gupta)**, c.399–414 CE.
Hiuen Tsang (Xuanzang)	Chinese monk; visited in the time of **Harsha**, 7th c. CE; book **Si-Yu-Ki**; studied at Nalanda; also visited Andhra (Amaravati, Dhanyakataka).
Al-Biruni	11th century (with Mahmud of Ghazni); book **Tahqiq-i-Hind** (belongs to the medieval volume).

1.5 Eras used in dating

Vikrama Samvat – 58 BCE · **Saka Era** – 78 CE (said to start with Kanishka; used by the Government of India's national calendar) · **Gupta Era** – 319–320 CE (Chandragupta I).
Three big divisions: **Prehistory** (no writing), **Protohistory** (writing exists but cannot be read – Indus), **History** (readable writing).

ANDHRA PRADESH / KURNOOL CONNECTION

Andhra evidence: Ashokan edicts at **Yerragudi and Rajula Mandagiri (Kurnool)**; **Bhattiprolu** (Guntur) relic casket inscriptions (early Brahmi); Satavahana inscriptions at Nashik, Nanaghat and Amaravati; Ptolemy's mention of **Kantakossyla (Ghantasala)**; earliest Telugu inscription: **Kalamalla (Kadapa) – Erikal Muturaju Dhananjaya, c.575 CE**.

EXAM TRAPS

Ashoka's edicts are the first **deciphered** inscriptions, but Harappan seals are older (undeciphered).
Kalhana's Rajatarangini = Kashmir history, first historical text; **Arthashastra** is not a history book but a manual of statecraft.
Fa-Hien = Gupta (Chandragupta II); Hiuen Tsang = Harsha. Do not swap.

2-MINUTE REVISION

Inscriptions most reliable · Prinsep 1837 · punch-marked coins oldest · Guptas most gold coins · Megasthenes–Indica–Chandragupta Maurya · Fa-Hien–Chandragupta II · Hiuen Tsang–Harsha.

CHECK YOURSELF

Q1. Who deciphered Ashokan Brahmi and when? **James Prinsep, 1837.** Q2. Which Chinese traveller visited during Harsha's rule? **Hiuen Tsang.** Q3. Which Gupta ruler had the most gold coin types? Guptas as a dynasty issued the most gold coins; **dinara** was the gold coin.

CHAPTER 2 — PREHISTORIC INDIA: FROM STONE TOOLS TO FIRST FARMERS

How humans learned to make tools, fire, pots and farms

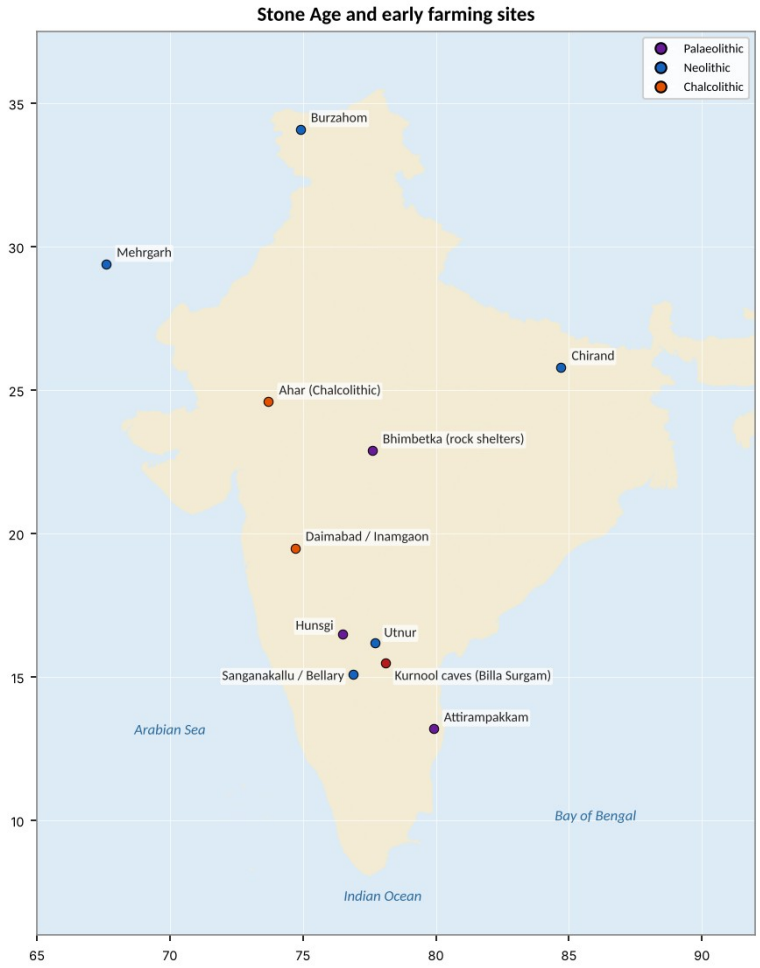


Fig 2.1 Important Stone Age and early farming sites (Kurnool caves in orange circle region of AP)

2.1 The idea: the Stone Age ladder

IN SIMPLE WORDS (what / how / why)

Early humans had no metal, so they used **stone** to cut, scrape and hunt. The Stone Age is divided by **what they could do**: only hunt and gather (Palaeolithic) → use tiny blades (Mesolithic) → farm and make pots (Neolithic) → mix copper with stone (Chalcolithic). Each step made life more settled and the population larger.

Age	Approx. period	Life and tools	Key sites
Palaeolithic (Old Stone)	up to c.10,000 BCE	Hunter-gatherers; cave/rock-shelter life; handaxes, cleavers, choppers (coarse quartzite); **fire** known; no pottery, no farming. Lower (Acheulian) → Middle (flakes) → Upper (blades).	Attirampakkam, Hunsgi, Bhimbetka, **Kurnool caves**, Renigunta
Mesolithic (Middle Stone)	c.10,000–6,000 BCE	**Microliths** (tiny stone tools fixed in wood/bone); warmer climate; hunting, fishing, **early domestication of animals**; famous **rock paintings**; burials.	Bagor (earliest animal domestication), Adamgarh, Bhimbetka, Langhnaj, Sarai Nahar Rai
Neolithic (New Stone)	c.7000–1000 BCE (varies by region)	**Polished stone axes (celts)**, **agriculture, pottery, settled villages**, wheel; cattle herding; mud-brick or pit houses.	Mehrgarh, Burzahom (pit houses, dogs buried with owners), Chirand (bone tools), Koldihwa (earliest rice), Maski, Brahmagiri, Utnur, Palavoy
Chalcolithic (Copper-Stone)	c.3000–700 BCE	**Copper + stone** tools, painted pottery; village farming; **no iron, no cities**; burials under house floors (Jorwe).	Ahar-Banas (Rajasthan), Kayatha, Malwa, Jorwe (Daimabad, Inamgaon), Navdatoli

2.2 Why farming changed everything

IN SIMPLE WORDS (what / how / why)

Hunters must keep moving after animals. Once people learned to **sow seeds and keep animals**, they could stay in one place. A **surplus** (extra grain) allowed some people to become potters, weavers or traders; groups grew into villages, and later cities. This